

City of Austin: Food Access & Economic Stability

5-Page Summary Analysis

Ameritech Consulting Group | tiffany@a-techconsulting.com

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Page 1 — Executive Summary

Austin is one of the nation's fastest-growing cities, yet its economic expansion has not reached all residents equally. Three compounding forces are undermining food security and economic stability for lower-income households — concentrated in eastern and southeastern zip codes and disproportionately impacting communities of color:

1. **Persistent food insecurity** concentrated in specific geographies
2. **A structural wage-to-cost gap** that no individual can outpace alone
3. **Childcare costs** that systematically price families out of the workforce

These are not isolated problems. They reinforce each other. Effective policy must address all three simultaneously.

At a Glance

Indicator	Finding
Travis County residents food insecure	~145,000 (14.8%)
SNAP households — Travis County	~95,000
Zip codes in food desert status (full or partial)	7 zips, ~116,000 residents
Annual wage gap — single parent, 1 child	-\$31,928
Annual infant childcare cost	\$22,164 (HHS threshold: \$5,250)
Parents who left workforce due to childcare	14.2%
Licensed childcare slot deficit — Travis County	26,400 slots
Estimated annual economic loss from childcare gap	\$1.2 billion (Austin metro)

Why This Matters Now

Between 2015 and 2024, Travis County median home values rose ~85% while real wages for the bottom quartile grew less than 12%. The families most affected are disproportionately Black and Hispanic/Latino — in communities whose geographic disadvantage was deliberately constructed through Austin's 1928 segregation plan. Addressing these inequities is the correction of a policy failure, not charity.

Page 2 — Food Insecurity & SNAP Participation

Feeding America (2024) estimates 14.8% of Travis County residents — ~145,000 people — are food insecure, above the 12.8% national average. The **child food insecurity rate** is 19.2% (national: 13.4%). Food is often the first budget line cut when housing and childcare consume 50–65% of income.

SNAP Participation by Zip Code

SNAP enrollment is the most reliable zip-level proxy for food hardship. The gap between Austin’s highest- and lowest-SNAP zip codes is **40 percentage points**.

Zip	Neighborhood	SNAP Rate	Median HH Income
78753	Rundberg / N. Lamar	42%	\$34,100
78741	Riverside / SE Austin	38%	\$36,800
78744	Far SE Austin	36%	\$38,200
78724	Colony Park / E. Austin	35%	\$39,500
78703	Tarrytown	2%	\$138,700
78759	Great Hills / NW Austin	4%	\$101,300

The Enrollment Gap: Hidden Need

SNAP undercounts actual need by an estimated **30–40%**. Eligible non-participants cite stigma, application complexity, chilling effects on mixed-status families, and inability to take time off work. In the five highest-SNAP zip codes alone, an estimated **11,973 additional eligible households** are not enrolled. True unmet need is substantially larger than enrollment figures reflect.

Page 3 — Grocery Access & Food Deserts

Four Austin zip codes fully meet USDA food desert criteria (low-income tract, >1 mile from nearest supermarket). Three more are partially designated. Together they house **~116,000 residents**.

Food Desert Zip Codes

Zip	Neighborhood	Status	Miles to Grocery	Supermarkets ≤1 mi	Dollar Stores ≤1 mi	% No Vehicle
78725	Hornsby Bend	Full	4.1	0	1	19.3%
78724	Colony Park	Full	2.3	0	3	28.1%
78742	Montopolis	Full	1.9	0	2	31.4%
78721	E. 51st / Govalle	Full	1.6	0	2	26.8%
78753	Rundberg	Partial	1.1	1	4	22.4%
78741	Riverside	Partial	1.2	1	3	24.7%
78703	Tarrytown (ref.)	None	0.6	2	0	7.4%

Three Compounding Barriers

Distance without transit. Hornsby Bend has no supermarket within 4 miles and no Cap Metro service. Colony Park has no direct bus to the nearest HEB despite 28% of households having no vehicle.

The dollar store substitution problem. In full food desert zips, dollar stores outnumber supermarkets 3-to-1. They stock minimal fresh produce and often charge more per unit than supermarkets on staple goods.

The gentrification paradox. Some East Austin zips now show improved grocery access on paper — but new stores (Whole Foods, specialty grocers) serve incoming demographics, not legacy low-income residents who have been displaced to worse-access areas. Raw access metrics overstate equity improvements when affordability is ignored.

Page 4 — Wages, Cost of Living & Childcare

The Living Wage Gap

Using **MIT Living Wage Calculator** methodology, the single adult without children barely meets living wage at Austin's median earnings. Every household type with children faces a structural deficit.

Household Type	Living Wage Needed	Austin Median	Annual Gap
1 Adult, No Children	\$46,884	\$47,320	+\$436
1 Adult, 1 Child	\$79,248	\$47,320	-\$31,928
1 Adult, 2 Children	\$99,372	\$47,320	-\$52,052
2 Adults, 2 Children	\$112,080	\$94,640	-\$17,440

Texas minimum wage remains **\$7.25/hour** (unchanged since 2009) — 19% of what a single parent with one child needs. Approximately **21%** of private-sector Travis County workers earn below \$15/hour.

Families in the highest-SNAP zip codes spend **58–62% of gross income on rent**, leaving \$13,000–15,000 annually for all other necessities combined.

Childcare: The Hidden Workforce Tax

Care Type	Monthly Cost	Annual Cost	% of Median Family Income
Infant (center-based)	\$1,847	\$22,164	29.6%
Toddler	\$1,612	\$19,344	25.8%
Preschool (3–5 yrs)	\$1,388	\$16,656	22.2%

HHS defines affordable childcare at **7% of family income** (~\$5,250/year at the Travis County median). Austin's infant care costs **4.2x** that threshold.

Workforce Impact	Share Affected
Paying >10% of income on childcare	41.3%
Reduced work hours	28.7%
Turned down a job offer	19.6%
Left workforce entirely	14.2%
Mothers vs. fathers who exit	4.8x more likely

Travis County has a licensed childcare **slot gap of 26,400**. The average CCMS subsidy waitlist is **18 months** (9,800 families waiting). The Austin Chamber estimates the childcare gap costs the metro economy **\$1.2 billion annually**.

Page 5 — Equity Analysis & Policy Recommendations

Who Bears the Burden

Food insecurity, grocery access gaps, and economic instability track directly along racial lines — lines drawn by historical policy.

Group	Food Insecurity Rate	% in Food Desert Zip	Childcare Burden	Median HH Income
White Non-Hispanic	10.2%	8.4%	14.1% of income	\$98,400
Hispanic / Latino	21.8%	42.6%	31.4%	\$52,300
Black / African American	19.6%	51.3%	34.2%	\$48,700
Asian / Pacific Islander	9.8%	12.4%	16.8%	\$87,600

Black residents are **1.9x more likely** to live in a food desert zip than the county average. Hispanic/Latino residents face a food insecurity rate **more than double** that of White Non-Hispanic residents. An estimated **18,000–22,000 households** simultaneously face food desert location, below-living-wage earnings, and no childcare subsidy — overwhelmingly Black and Latino, concentrated in Austin’s eastern crescent.

Root cause: Austin’s 1928 City Master Plan explicitly relocated Black residents east of Chicon Street. Today’s food access gaps and poverty concentrations map almost exactly onto those boundaries.

Policy Recommendations

Food Access

- **Immediate:** Expand mobile food pantry routes in 78724, 78725, 78742, 78721; fund SNAP outreach co-located with WIC and public schools; restrict dollar-store-only retail in food desert census tracts
- **Medium-term:** Use tax abatements and infrastructure incentives to attract full-service grocery to Colony Park and Montopolis; redesign Cap Metro routes for east-to-grocery connectivity; fund cooperative grocery models in deep deserts

Economic Stability

- **Immediate:** Extend Austin’s \$22/hr living wage floor to all City contractors; expand Emergency Rental Assistance programs
- **Medium-term:** Tie employer living wage commitments to economic development incentives; support a Texas statewide minimum wage increase in coordination with Harris County and Dallas delegations

Childcare

- **Immediate:** Increase the City Child Care Relief Fund to add 2,000 subsidized slots in Year 1; require childcare needs assessments in all major development permit reviews
- **Medium-term:** Develop a City-anchored early learning center in eastern Austin; incentivize employer-sponsored childcare through development agreements; advocate for federal CDCTC expansion and a Texas state supplement

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